

subscription model where drivers pay the company a fixed amount for using the application. It lets customers select their preferred driver and fare, while drivers can view the pick-up and drop locations along with the expected earnings.

"I guess a new revolution happens every decade and it is time for that in the ride-hailing space—be it new EV fleets coming in or commission-free applications like us, [we] are coming in to bridge the gap and fix the broken pieces. They (Ola and Uber) know that they are losing this market and [if they] invest more money they will only increase their losses," says Firdosh Sheikh, Co-founder and CEO of Drife.

RICKSHAW RETURNS

It isn't just cabs that are jostling behind Ola and Uber; there is also the humble autorickshaw. A burgeoning crowd of dissatisfied customers is hitching autorickshaw rides for the daily commute.

According to one market observer, during 2018-19, Ola led this segment with approximately 400,000–500,000 rides per day, and with Uber's entry in 2018, the duo collectively accounted for about 600,000–700,000 daily rides. During the pandemic, a considerable number of autos shifted to online platforms, resulting in substantial growth, reaching an impressive 1.5 million rides per day shared between Ola, Uber, Rapido, and Namma Yatri.

Since its foray into the segment in 2020, Bengaluru-based Rapido has made steady progress, and currently operates in 35 cities. According to Co-founder Pavan Guntupalli, Rapido currently facilitates around half-a-million rides and holds the top slot in the three-wheeler segment in Hyderabad,



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"We said...we will go back to basics, [to] what a customer needs when booking a cab—be on time, give a clean cab and one he can afford"

TUSHAR GARG
CO-FOUNDER AND CBO, BLUSMART

while it is also nearing the second spot in several other markets. Rapido began as a bike taxi service and is currently the leader in that segment. "Auto rides have grown 30-35 per cent year-on-year (YoY) in the last one year. We anticipate 30 per cent YoY growth for auto and 50 per cent YoY growth for bikes," says Guntupalli.

Bengaluru-based auto booking app Namma Yatri, which works on the ONDC network, has garnered about 20-25 per cent of the market share in the city in less than seven months. The app was built by Juspay Technologies on behalf of the autorickshaw drivers' union amid an escalating dispute between the Karnataka transport department and Ola and Uber over higher fares. It now has a fleet network of over 81,000 autos and has completed over 5.7 million rides so far.

Like with Namma Yatri, ONDC's core principles of unbundling and interoperability are expected to help it create a new ecosystem that can address the online mobility industry's inadequacies. "ONDC unbundles demand and supply as two separate businesses where any large consumer app can become the buyer and any dedicated mobility player can become the seller by on-boarding drivers or vehicles," explains Nitin Nair, Senior VP of ONDC.

ONDC is currently looking to include cabs and other modes of transport, and plans to launch in multiple cities. Large consumer applications such as Paytm and PhonePe are also expected to launch mobility verticals on their apps.

Clearly, the ride-hailing market is entering an intriguing phase. **BT**

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